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A Hamitic kingdom in the center of Africa

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Chapter 4 Offices of a Recreational and Literary Nature

<u>Umurir' ugatiny' amazi.</u>	Fire fears water.	412 General Tools
<u>Amaz (i)' atiny' ifu.</u>	Water fears flour. (3)	538 Literature
<u>If' itiny' amenyo.</u>	Flour fears teeth (4) .	539 Literary Texts
<u>Ameny' atiny' umuhoro.</u>	Teeth fear the billhook (iron) (5) .	
<u>Table Notes:</u>		
3. "Water fears flour," that is to say, the bread or "mush" into which it vanishes.		
4. "Flour fears the teeth" of those who eat it.		
5. "Teeth fear the billhook," as all other hard bodies, especially when made of iron, like the billhook, which is one of the most useful tools. The Blacks of Ruanda have a rich and varied oral literature. They like witticisms, and since their language is rich in shades and nuances, they manipulate it with great art.		

The most refined speech is heard at the capital.	538 Literature
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The habitual frequenters of the court, lords, courtiers, and employees, express themselves in flawless language, use the right words and choice expressions, and give them the proper inflections, for Runyarwanda is a phonetic /sic/ language. The appointed men of letters, storytellers, bards, genealogists, and historians carefully watch their diction. Among them conversation is never dull, for jokes and witticisms abound.

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Considering the good taste that distinguishes the familiars of the king and the inhabitants of the central province of Nduga, it is not  180 surprising that they should be shocked and amused by the lingo of the mountain dwellers and those who inhabit the frontiers of the realm. The latter's language is far from refined. It teems with syntactical and accentual mistakes and contains a mixture of foreign terms borrowed from the tongues of neighboring groups.

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